Draft: pending clinical review

Checking your blood pressure at home

How to measure, how to write it down, and when to get help: with a record to bring to every visit

The 5 things to remember

- Use a validated **upper-arm cuff**: not a wrist device or smartwatch.
- **Sit quietly for 5 minutes**, then take **2 readings, 1 minute apart**.
- Before each visit, measure **morning and evening for 7 days**.
- Write down **every** reading, high or low. Bring this record, your device and your medicines to every visit.
- **180/120 or higher** with chest pain, weakness or trouble speaking: **call 997**.

Why check at home?

Blood pressure is often higher at the clinic than at home. Home readings show your usual blood pressure and help your doctor decide on your treatment.

Which device should I use?

- An automatic **upper-arm** monitor that is **validated**: ask your doctor or pharmacist, or check the STRIDE BP list.
- The cuff must fit your arm. A large arm needs a large cuff.
- Wrist monitors and smartwatches are not accurate enough yet.

How do I measure correctly?

Before	During
No coffee, tea, smoking, shisha or exercise for 30 minutes.	Sit with your back supported and both feet flat on the floor.
Empty your bladder.	Do not cross your legs.
Sit quietly for 5 minutes.	Rest your arm on a table at the level of your heart.
In the morning: measure before your medicines and before breakfast.	Cuff on bare skin, just above the elbow. Do not talk.

Use the same arm each time: the one your doctor tells you. If the monitor shows a heart symbol for an irregular heartbeat, write **IHB** in the notes.

When should I measure?

When	How often
The 7 days before each visit	Every day: **2 readings in the morning** and **2 in the evening**.
After a change in your blood pressure medicine	The same 7-day plan, when your doctor tells you.
When your blood pressure is under control	1–2 days a week, or the 7 days before each visit: as your doctor advises.
When you feel unwell (dizzy, headache)	Measure, write it down with how you feel, and follow the box below.

How do I write it down?

- Write the date and **every** reading exactly as shown, high or low, as top/bottom: for example **128/82**. Do not round.
- Use the notes to say if you missed a medicine, felt unwell, or the monitor showed IHB.
- Do not change your medicines because of one reading. Bring the record, and your monitor or app, to your visit.

What do my numbers mean?

For most adults the target is **below 130/80**. Some people need a lower target and some older adults a higher one: your doctor will write yours on the record.

NOW **Call 997 or go to the emergency department**

- **180/120 or higher** with chest pain, shortness of breath, weakness or numbness, trouble speaking, confusion, sudden change in vision, or a sudden severe headache.
- You faint.

TODAY **Contact your clinic today (or call 937)**

- **180/120 or higher** again after resting 5 minutes, and you feel well.
- Top number **below 90**, or you feel dizzy or faint when you stand up.

NEXT VISIT **Bring to your next visit**

- Most readings above your target.
- Side effects of your medicines, or questions.

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This leaflet gives general information. It does not replace advice from your own doctor, who knows your health. Bring it to your next visit and ask about anything that is unclear. Written with AI assistance, checked by the medical editor, and still under review with colleagues.

Last updated: October 2026 · **Next review:** October 2027, or sooner if guidance changes

Sources:

1. Jones DW, et al. 2025 AHA/ACC/multisociety guideline for the prevention, detection, evaluation and management of high blood pressure in adults. Circulation / Hypertension 2025
2. Mancia G, et al. 2023 ESH guidelines for the management of arterial hypertension. J Hypertens 2023;41:1874–2071
3. Stergiou GS, et al. 2021 European Society of Hypertension practice guidelines for office and out-of-office blood pressure measurement. J Hypertens 2021;39:1293–302
4. NICE NG136. Hypertension in adults: diagnosis and management (updated 2023)
5. STRIDE BP. International list of validated blood pressure monitors (stridebp.org)

My blood pressure record

BRING TO EVERY VISIT

Name: _____ File number: _____

Arm used (right / left): _____ Cuff size: _____

My target (written by my doctor): _____

My blood pressure medicines and times: _____

Write each reading as top/bottom (for example 128/82). Morning: before medicines and breakfast. Evening: before dinner.

The 7 days before my visit

Day	Date	Morning 1	Morning 2	Evening 1	Evening 2	Notes
e.g.	*15/10*	*136/86*	*132/84*	*128/80*	*126/80*	*missed evening tablet*
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						
7						

For the clinic

Average of days 2–7: _____ Number of readings: _____ Reviewed by / date: _____

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Between visits

BRING TO EVERY VISIT

Use this page for readings on other days: when your doctor asks, when you feel unwell, or after a medicine change.

Date	Time	Reading	Pulse	Medicines taken today? (✓ / ×)	How I felt / notes

Questions for my next visit